

Inferential data

Data Brokers love connected devices. The more gadgets and appliances turn smart, the more data becomes available for data brokers to collect and sell. In this world where human beings have become the product, the data about said customers has turned out to become a valuable commodity. Your smartphones have been having a field day and every smart home gizmo in your house has been secretly listening in on everything uttered within earshot. Companies always claim that the data is anonymised and that the data is never stored anywhere but time and time again, we've seen how we're being lied to. The latest source for data collection are home appliances which, for some silly reason, need to be connected to the internet.

There was this news piece a couple of months ago about washing machines uploading 3.7 GBs worth of data every day. Think about it this way, washing machines are one of the dumbest gadgets that we have. And they literally don't need to get smarter. Anyone who's taken a class in logic design will know that the code for even the most complicated wash cycle can be accommodated within a few kilobytes. In fact, most of the cheap washing machines use a microcontroller with just 32-256 KB of programmable memory. You can make do with much less. With the advent of AI smart washing machines, we've got a little more complicated cycles with smarter adjustments but nothing really needs 'AI'. It's all just another gimmick to sell stuff at a premium.

One thing that's largely gone under the radar are automobiles. Every car since the '70s has had a small chip in it. And of late, more and more automobiles are shipping with a decked out infotainment system that makes your riding experience much better. You've got Android integration, driver assist features, driver monitoring features and much more. All of these features are very much welcome as value adds but when they start transmitting every bit about you to unknown entities, it becomes a problem.

Automobiles collect diagnostics data, location information, usage data, driver behaviour, etc. Most of the above mentioned telemetry data wouldn't come as a surprise but medical information, genetic data, your intelligence levels, etc. should come as a surprise. And if



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your insurance premiums go up, largely thanks to this data being shared with your insurance provider without your consent, you know whom to blame. Details pertaining to the data being collected is mentioned in your user manual using broad and vague terminology. For example, the word 'demographics' could mean anything from your physical characteristics, race, gender, credit information, etc. So it's not like car companies aren't informing you. You're mostly not bothered about reading the fine print, like every other contract or EULA that you've ever clicked through. For all you know, your next insurance claim would be denied because the insurance company gets one little snippet of information that has voided your right to the claim. Legally, they have the right to do so because you've consented to sharing the data with the car company and other third-parties.

On one hand, there's additional accountability. Because you are now aware that there's no way you can lie your way to getting an insurance claim, you will drive safer. That's good for everyone. On the other hand, you can never lend your car to anyone else simply because if they ever do anything unsafe, then you will have to pay the price. And since people don't read the terms and conditions of policies, you will commit mistakes. Over time, your insurance premiums would skyrocket. And the 'demographics' data is actually clubbed with third-party data to 'infer' more information about you. So even if you, personally, happen to be the safest driver on the planet but people in your demographics are quite the opposite, then statistically, your insurance premiums have to be higher. That stings, doesn't it?

So what can you do? Read the terms and conditions! Opt out wherever possible. There are modifications that can be done to the car instruments and you can pull out fuses powering these systems, but none of that is advisable since you could put your life in danger. You don't always have to dive deep into the digital world. Keeping a little distance is always prudent. You'll learn more in this issue as we explore Digital Detoxing and the numerous ways you can reset yourself. Do write in to us to let us know if you found any of our tips helpful. **d**